

**STUCK IN YOUR HEAD: Understanding Overthinking Among College Students and Ways to
Manage It**



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I. Introduction

College life can be stressful because students have to deal with different responsibilities such as assignments, examinations, projects, deadlines, social relationships, and concerns about their future. Because of these situations, students may spend a lot of time thinking about problems even when there is no immediate action that they can take. This can lead to a habit commonly described as overthinking.

Overthinking is not a formal mental health diagnosis. However, the idea is closely related to rumination, which refers to repeatedly thinking about negative experiences, problems, or emotions. Research involving college students has found that rumination and stress are related to psychological distress. A longitudinal study involving 161 undergraduate students found that rumination and stress interacted significantly in predicting aspects of psychological distress.

The problem becomes more concerning when repeated thinking does not help a person solve the problem and instead causes more worry, stress, difficulty concentrating, or difficulty moving forward. This is especially relevant to students because mental health problems can also affect educational functioning. According to the World Health Organization (WHO), approximately 1 in 7 adolescents aged 10–19 worldwide experience a mental health condition, with anxiety and depression among the leading conditions affecting this age group.

This project aims to explain how overthinking can affect students, present relevant information about repetitive negative thinking and student mental health, and provide simple strategies that students can use to manage excessive worrying and repetitive thoughts.

II. Problem Description

Overthinking can occur when a student repeatedly thinks about the same situation without reaching a decision or solution. For example, a student may continue thinking about an examination even after studying, repeatedly worry about receiving a low grade, or keep thinking about a mistake made during a presentation.

The cycle may start with a simple problem such as:

“What if I fail my exam?”

The student may then begin thinking about possible negative outcomes. This can lead to more worry, which can create additional negative thoughts. Instead of focusing on what can actually be done, the student becomes focused on possible outcomes that may not even happen.

This can be represented as:

Problem → Repeated Thoughts → Worry → Stress → More Thoughts

Research supports the relationship between repetitive negative thinking and student mental health. A systematic review and meta-analysis of university undergraduate students found that negative rumination was a significant predictor of depression outcomes. The review included eight studies involving 13,790 participants for its pooled depression analysis, which estimated a pooled prevalence of depression of 25%.

Another systematic review examining predictors of depressive symptoms included 25,154 college students across 24 cohort studies. Negative automatic thoughts and negative rumination were among the factors identified as predictors of depressive symptoms.

These findings do not mean that overthinking directly causes depression in every student. Instead, they show that repetitive negative thinking is an important factor that can be associated with poorer psychological outcomes.

For students, this problem may appear through different situations such as academic pressure, fear of failure, uncertainty about the future, relationship problems, financial concerns, and mistakes from the past. When these thoughts become repetitive, they can interfere with a student's ability to focus on the present task.

The World Health Organization also identifies healthy sleep, regular physical activity, coping skills, problem-solving skills, and emotional management as important factors in supporting adolescent mental health.

III. Effects of Overthinking on Students

Overthinking can affect students in different ways depending on the situation and how frequently the repetitive thoughts occur.

1. Difficulty Concentrating

When a student's mind is focused on repeated worries, it can become more difficult to concentrate on studying, assignments, or other responsibilities. Instead of focusing on the current task, the student may continue thinking about a previous mistake or worrying about a future outcome.

2. Increased Stress

Repeatedly thinking about problems can increase feelings of stress. Research involving college students found that rumination and stress can interact in predicting psychological distress.

3. Sleep Problems

Overthinking may also become noticeable at night when there are fewer distractions. A student may continue thinking about assignments, examinations, conversations, or future responsibilities instead of preparing for sleep. Maintaining healthy sleep patterns is identified by WHO as an important part of adolescent mental well-being.

4. Difficulty Making Decisions

Overthinking can cause a person to repeatedly consider different possibilities without actually making a decision. This can result in procrastination because the student continues thinking about what could happen instead of taking the next step.

5. Negative Self-Reflection

Thinking about mistakes can sometimes be useful because it allows a person to learn from them. However, repeatedly criticizing oneself about the same mistake can become unproductive. Research involving college students has found relationships between rumination, self-criticism, and psychological functioning.

IV. Proposed Solution

The proposed solution for managing overthinking is a simple “STOP, SORT, SOLVE, AND MOVE” approach. The goal is not to completely stop thinking, because thinking is necessary for problem-solving. Instead, the goal is to recognize when thinking becomes repetitive and redirect it toward something useful.

1. STOP – Recognize the Thought

The first step is to recognize when the same thought keeps appearing repeatedly.

For example:

“I keep thinking about whether I will fail even though I already studied.”

Recognizing the pattern can help the student understand that the problem is no longer simply studying for the examination, but repeatedly worrying about the possible result.

2. SORT – Separate Facts From Assumptions

Students can write down what they actually know and separate it from what they are only imagining.

FACT:

“I have an examination tomorrow.”

ASSUMPTION:

“I am definitely going to fail.”

This helps prevent possible outcomes from being treated as facts.

3. SOLVE – Focus on What Can Be Controlled

Instead of repeatedly asking:

“What if I fail?”

The student can ask:

“What can I do right now?”

The answer could be reviewing one chapter, asking a classmate for help, preparing materials, or studying for another 30 minutes.

This changes the thought from worrying about an outcome to taking an action.

4. MOVE – Take a Healthy Break

After taking action, students should give themselves time away from the problem. Walking, exercising, listening to music, spending time with friends, or doing another activity can provide a mental break.

Research on mindfulness-based interventions among university students found improvements in areas including distress, anxiety, depression, well-being, and rumination compared with passive control groups, although the researchers also noted limitations in the quality of some of the available studies.

5. SEEK SUPPORT WHEN NEEDED

If repetitive thoughts become difficult to manage or begin significantly affecting school, sleep, relationships, or daily activities, students should consider seeking support from a trusted person, school counselor, or qualified mental-health professional.

WHO emphasizes the importance of supportive environments, early identification, and access to appropriate mental-health care for young people.

V. Expected Impact

The proposed approach is intended to help students recognize unproductive thinking and respond to it in a more practical way. Instead of spending a long time imagining possible negative outcomes, students can learn to identify what they can control and take small actions toward solving the problem.

The expected benefits include:

- Better awareness of repetitive negative thoughts
- Improved focus on academic responsibilities
- Better management of everyday stress
- More practical decision-making
- Healthier ways of coping with worries
- Improved balance between academic work and personal well-being

The main objective is not to eliminate every negative thought. Negative thoughts are a normal part of life. Instead, students should learn how to recognize when their thoughts are becoming repetitive and redirect their attention toward useful actions.

VI. Conclusion

Overthinking is a common experience that can become a problem when repetitive thoughts begin interfering with a student's daily activities, concentration, sleep, and emotional well-being. Although overthinking itself is not a formal mental health diagnosis, research on related concepts such as rumination shows that repetitive negative thinking can be associated with stress and poorer psychological outcomes among students.

College students face many situations that can encourage excessive worrying, including academic requirements, examinations, deadlines, relationships, and uncertainty about the future. Because of this, learning how to manage repetitive thoughts is an important part of maintaining healthy study habits and overall well-being.

The STOP, SORT, SOLVE, AND MOVE approach provides a simple way for students to deal with these situations. By recognizing repetitive thoughts, separating facts from assumptions, focusing on controllable actions, taking healthy breaks, and seeking support when necessary, students can develop more practical ways of handling their worries.

Ultimately, not every thought needs to be solved immediately. Sometimes, the best response to overthinking is to recognize the thought, focus on what can be controlled, and take one small step forward.

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